

From Fanfiction to Fancasting: Produser Evolution in the *Harry Potter* Fandom

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Harry Potter has proven itself one of the most seminal media entities of the last 25 years and currently remains the most written-about series to date on multiple fanfiction platforms. Its globally vast franchise has seeped into every corner of the media landscape. A franchise's success can almost always be attributed to the continual consumption of its fandom. However, a fan is not just one who consumes.

One of the central voices in fandom studies, Henry Jenkins, defines fan culture as *participatory culture*. He claims that one does not become a fan by the simple act of consuming; they must also translate their viewing into another form of “cultural activity” (Jenkins, 1988). Fan writing is one of these activities. The concept of fan-generated content, such as fanfiction, aligns with Axel Bruns' term *produser*, referring to consumers who engage in the “continuous building and extending of existing content” (Bruns, 2007).

In the Web 2.0 world, fanwriting has steadily increased, probably incited by the internet-incentivizing lockdown of 2020 (Google Trends, n.d.). This growth in fan activity has given way to a newer phenomenon in the world of fanfiction: *fancasting*. Fancasting refers to the process of fans sharing their dream set of actors or casting choices for potential adaptations of their beloved media. As fancasting is a newer concept within the realm of fandom studies, for which little to no formal research exists, I seek to further establish its existence. I will do so by using *Harry Potter* fanfiction as a starting point, as it is a widely researched text within fan studies, and many multi-fandom individuals are likely to have interacted with it in some form. My research explores the following questions:

- Why do fans engage in fancasting?
- What is the relationship between fanfiction readers/writers and fancasting?

- Can fan-generated content affect industry media?

I conclude that fanfiction and fancasting are intertwined forms of participatory *produsage* that negotiate between fan desire and official content. While fancasting's direct influence on industry content is rare, the findings still exhibit a significant evolution between audience and producer and its affective properties. The following sections establish my theoretical approach by examining the dimensions of fan engagement. I will then present the findings from interviews with fanfiction readers and writers, and examples from remote observation (Google Trends, Reddit, Archive of our Own [AO3]).

Conceptual Background

The concepts of participatory culture and the produser both place unique agency upon the fan to engage with popular media through creation (Jenkins, 1988; Bruns, 2007). The produser focuses more on the fan itself, while participatory culture theory describes the interactive communities or fandoms they reside in. Many media scholars employ this notion of the produser, arguing that the role of the audience has blended into that of the producer (Athique, 2016).

This paper also adopts Peter Dahlgren and Annette Hill's parameters of media engagement to provide a critical methodology for dissecting and classifying fan behaviour (Dahlgren & Hill, 2020). Crucially, this paper focuses on the parameters of *motivation* (intention behind engagement) and *modalities* (affective and cognitive modes of engagement) to interpret the rationale behind an audience's fancasting.

Methodology, Design, and Ethics

I employed a two-step qualitative approach: participant interviews followed by remote reception. To collect interviewees promptly, I used convenience sampling to target the niche audience cohort: fanfiction readers or writers who have heard the term fancasting. After posing the question, “Have you ever read or written fanfiction?” to all those I came across over a few weeks, I selected the first five participants who responded affirmatively. I decided upon an interview format over a survey, hoping to encourage free-flowing conversation and anecdote-sharing that may have been left out if they were required to type. Then, I created standard, specific questions posed to each participant in the same manner and recorded their answers. Since this cohort was small-scale, I also conducted larger-scale quantitative research on Google Trends, followed by AO3 and Reddit, as they were the most mentioned in the interviews.

I encountered a few ethical challenges. One problem was that of universality, as my interview sample was small, specific, and non-random. This means that my results cannot be broadly applied to all fancasters but rather used as a jumping-off point. I discovered another issue in the participant collection phase: certain individuals were embarrassed to talk about fandom and fanfiction, a frequently satirized topic. To circumvent this, I began each interview with a declaration of confidentiality, promising that participants would only be referred to under pseudonyms. Persistence over an extended length of time yielded positive results, as my desired five participants were found. Considering this design and its subsequent restrictions, the yielded results remain notable.

Interview Results

The aforementioned limitation of a convenience sample rendered all my participants members of similar socio-economic contexts. Responses to the demographic-oriented questions (occupation, gender, and sexuality) were as expected. Five self-identified as students, and four of them were also part-time workers. Three identified as cisgender women, one as a genderfluid woman, and the other as a transmasculine person. Regarding sexuality, all were LGBTQ+, except for one who was unlabeled.

Concerning engagement with fanfiction, all were pre-screened to have read it, and three were also writers. All had interacted with *Harry Potter* fanfiction in some capacity, and they all described familiarity with the idea of fancasting, with two having also participated in it. I posed the following questions:

Q1: In your opinion, why do you and/or others engage in fancasting?

Q2: Do you think fan-made content (including fanfiction writing and fancasting) ever affects subsequent industry content?

The recurring themes in response to Q1 were:

- An accessible outlet of creative expression
- A collectively imaginative form of engagement
- To intensify feelings of involvement, empowerment, and control
- Ability to propose more diverse representations

Responses to Q2 were more abstract, but all agreed that fan-generated content can impact industry content. Two participants, Annie and Willow, referenced a fancasting of the most-read fanfiction on AO3 within the *Harry Potter* universe, called *All the Young Dudes* by MsKingBean89. The story's two main characters, Sirius Black and Remus Lupin, have been

widely fancast, with the fandom agreeing on Andrew Garfield as Remus and Ben Barnes as Sirius. My participants explained that this famous fancasting ended up reaching the actors. This is significant as it was affective, even though it didn't result in further media production. Another participant, Quinn, references DreamWorks' *Voltron: Legendary Defender* and a commonly shipped duo in the show, Lance and Keith. The show creators took notice of increased fanwriting and interest, then gave them more screentime, which Quinn considered queerbaiting as it never became canon. This is an example of fan production as direct talk with professional producers, regardless of how the final product was received.

Remote Reception Results

To obtain a more quantitative picture of fancasting and its relevance, I conducted a Google Trends search using the filters “worldwide” and “2004-present.” Figure 1 looks at the general word ‘fancasting’, which shows a gradual incline in March of 2020. Figure 2 specifically targets the terms ‘Harry Potter fancast’, showing the same steady rise since January 2020, but peaking in January 2022 and declining since.

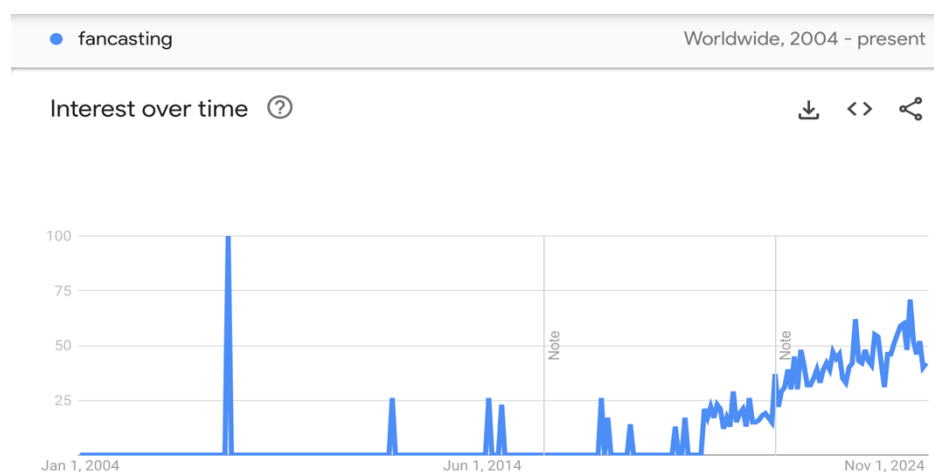


Fig 1. Google Trends result for “fancasting” (Google Trends, n.d.-a)

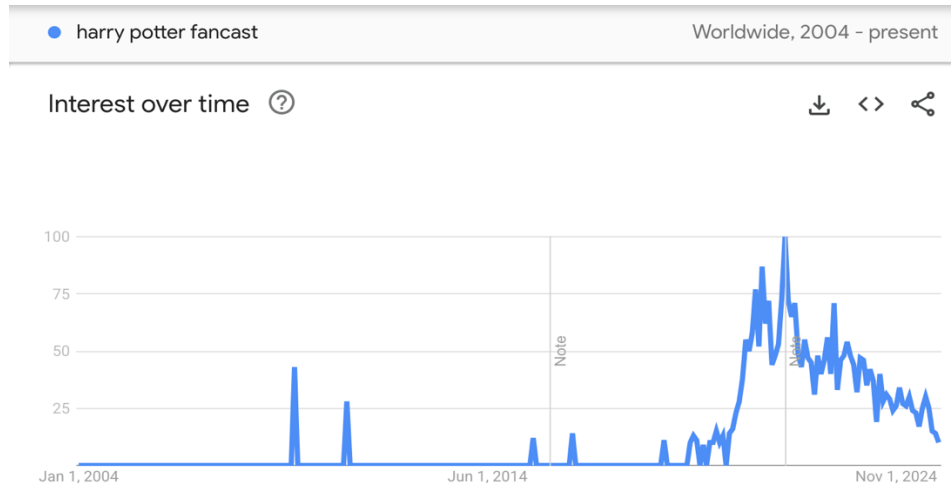


Fig 2. Google Trends result for “Harry Potter fancast” (Google Trends, n.d.-b).

Searching for visual examples of fancasting, I turned to Reddit and selected two of the thousands of posts I came across. Figure 3 is a representative visual example of what fancasts can look like, this one pertaining to the upcoming HBO *Harry Potter* television series. Figure 4 is a more imaginative example, where the user imagines *Harry Potter* movies filmed in the 90s, casting Johnny Depp as Sirius Black.

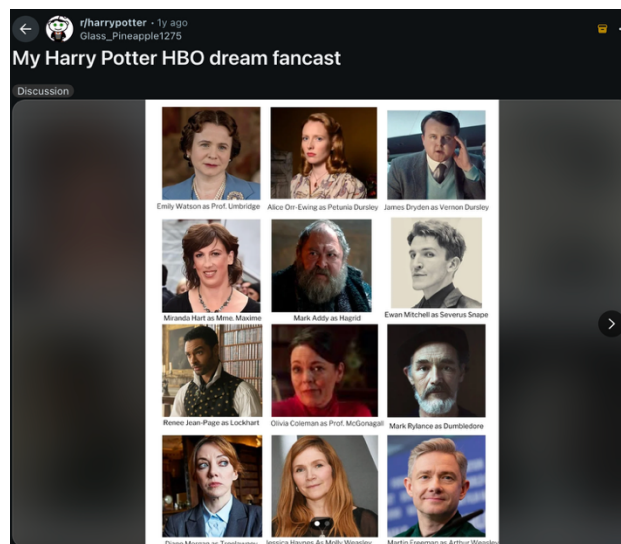


Fig. 3 (Glass_Pineapple1275, 2023)

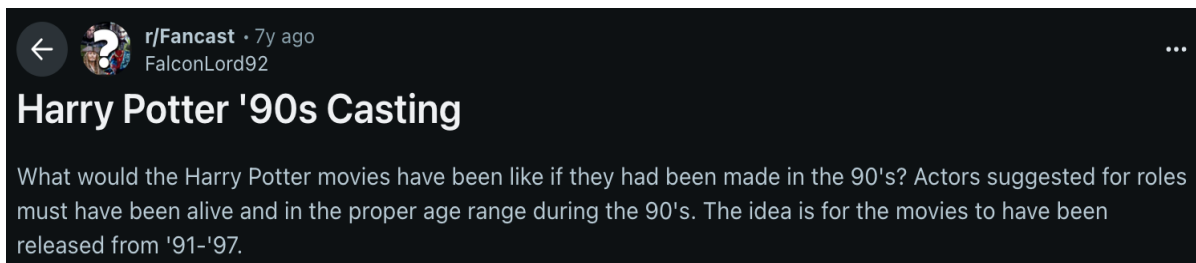


Fig. 4 (FalconLord92, 2018)

Finally, I consulted AO3 to establish *Harry Potter* fanfiction's continually rising popularity, positioning fancasting as a worthy source of attention. "AO3 Ship Stats" is a multi-year user-made project outlining the top written-about *ships* (relationships) since 2013. Since the project's inception, at least one *Harry Potter* ship has sat in the top ten. This has recently increased, from 2023 having 2/10 *Harry Potter*-related ships to 2025 having 5/10. This is likely due to the new video game *Hogwarts Legacy* and the upcoming HBO television show.

AO3 Ship Stats: Summer 2025							
THIS YEAR'S TOP 100							
by centreoftheselights							
Rank	Change	Relationship	Fandom	Works Gained	Total Works	Type	Race
1	Re-Entry	Jayce/Viktor (League of Legends)	Arcane: League of Legends (Cartoon 2021)	13261	15891	M/M	Latino White
2	+5	Evan "Buck" Buckley/Eddie Diaz (9-1-1 TV)	9-1-1 (TV)	11202	35156	M/M	White Latino
3	Re-Entry	Caitlyn/Vi (League of Legends)	Arcane: League of Legends (Cartoon 2021)	9965	16574	F/F	Asian White
4	+9	Bakugou Katsuki/Midoriya Izuku	Boku no Hero Academia My Hero Academia	8140	50992	M/M	Asian Asian
5	-3	Sirius Black/Remus Lupin	Harry Potter - J. K. Rowling	7523	57803	M/M	White White
6	+15	James Potter/Lily Evans Potter	Harry Potter - J. K. Rowling	7329	34076	F/M	White White
7	+1	Regulus Black/James Potter	Harry Potter - J. K. Rowling	6477	21988	M/M	White White
8	+12	Hermione Granger/Draco Malfoy	Harry Potter - J. K. Rowling	5862	34817	F/M	Ambig White
9	-6	Dazai Osamu/Nakahara Chuuya (Bungou Stray Dogs)	文豪ストレイドッグス Bungou Stray Dogs	4921	37637	M/M	Asian Asian
10	-1	Draco Malfoy/Harry Potter	Harry Potter - J. K. Rowling	4915	69576	M/M	White White

Fig. 5 (Centreoftheselights, 2025)

Discussion

My hypothesis of an interdependence between fanfiction producers and fancasting, and the relation to the 2020 pandemic, was affirmed by the results. This audience cohort seemed to share an appreciation of the opportunity to “collectively engage” with their favourite media. Benedict Anderson’s concept of “imagined communities” defines dedicated fandoms with shared sets of interactions; this dedication and intention fall within the engagement parameter of motivation (Anderson, 1983; Dahlgren & Hill, 2020). Scholar Sue Turnbull quotes Anderson’s imagined communities, viewing them as integral to a fan’s self-expression (Turnbull, 2020b). Self-expression and fancasting as a creative outlet, like in the case of the 90’s fancast, fall neatly in line with produser theory (Bruns, 2007), where fans treat a program like “silly putty” in their stretching and remoulding of narrative (Jenkins, 2012a). This builds upon the aspect of accessibility noted by interviewees, which is a marker of participatory culture characterized by “universal accessibility” (Athique, 2016; Jenkins, 1988). This accessibility breeds affective agency, reaffirmed by Q2 responses, specifically the one involving *Voltron: Legendary Defender*. This example aligns with Dahlgren and Hill’s affective modality parameter, outlining a kind of conversation between media and fan where feelings are shared, and the source is then affected (Dahlgren & Hill, 2020).

Conclusion and Implications

This paper weaves together the theories of participatory culture, the produser, and media engagement parameters to conclude that fancasting is a necessary evolution of the affective produser. Though rarely influencing official content, the research deepens understanding of a newer fandom studies concept, fancasting, as a necessary consequence of contemporary

participatory culture. By providing a better foundation for future research, this work can be used to analyze the emerging interactive forms that are integral to our rapidly changing media landscape.

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